

Big little super-computer

Clustering is fast becoming a reliable means of extracting super-crunching power. The third most powerful supercomputer consists of 1,100 dual-processor Apple G5 computers. Dubbed the Big Mac, it clocked in



10.3 teraflops per second.

Another interesting system is a TV-sized model that consists of 1,000 CPUs based on the Power PC processor technology. The project's goal is to build a computer capable of one thousand trillion operations per second.

Interestingly, processor technology will also be the foundation of the new gaming consoles from Nintendo and Sony. Sony claims that the Cell processor—the heart of the upcoming PlayStation 3—is capable of being a super-computer on a chip. The processor used in the mini-supercomputer contains five network controllers and 4 MB of L3 memory, and runs at 700 MHz.

The chips are less expensive and consume less power than traditional microprocessors, making it possible to pack the same amount of computing power into a smaller space.

Walkie-talkies of the near future

Nokia recently announced the 5140 cell phone, touting it as a walkie-talkie for the masses. The 5140 is based on push-to-talk technology that lets you chat instantly with fellow 5140s at the push of a button.

The unit is a tri-band model slated for release in the second half of 2004. It will be priced between \$150 and \$200 in the US; Asian pricing has not yet been announced. It also sports a digital compass, an integrated VGA camera, and support for the GPRS and EDGE com-



munication technologies.

Samsung Electronics, in reply, announced the SCH-V410 that records up to 2 hours of video! It also offers an MP3 player with dedicated external buttons that act as a universal remote control of sorts, for home appliances.

The inbuilt camera claims to compensate for backlighting and sports a flash. You can also play back video on its 262,000-colour TFT internal screen and extra information on the 16-grey OLED external screen. Currently a Korea-only model, the unit is priced at around \$600.

tomorrow's technology

Plastic Memory

Research at Princeton University and Hewlett-Packard's HP Labs has revealed a new way to store data on plastic. The memory is built using a combination of plastic foil and silicon. Data is stored by applying a strong current to a polymer fuse, blowing it and changing its conductivity. Lower voltages are used to determine which fuses are blown, thereby determining the zeros and ones that make up digital data. Data is stored perma-

nently. This suits applications such as accounting and digital imaging. Recently, AMD bought Coatue, a company that is developing plastic memory with 15 times the storage capacity of DRAMs. Earlier this year, researchers from the Indian Association for the Cultivation of Science and the Italian National Research Council unveiled another technique for storing data on plastic, but the memory was not stable for more than an hour.

quoteworthy

"I'm getting a lot of advice...One person suggested we unload Java. There's a good idea. Ford, why don't you unload cars?"

Sun CEO, Scott McNealy on the suggestions received by the company

"I think God put me on this world to challenge big companies."

Michael Robertson, CEO Lindows, when asked why he was always gunning for the top players

"It's no fun to go into a market that Microsoft is in, but it's even worse to go into a market they aren't in"

Senior Vice President for Macromedia, David Mendels, referring to the expected competition from Microsoft

snapshot

Intel invested over **US \$200 million** in more than **100** companies world-wide last **year**

Source: venturewire.com

■ Korea plans to wire the entire country with a 50-100 Mbps network ■ Yahoo! launches a toolbar with popup blocker ■ Wal-Mart plans to open an online music store

